

TEST PROCESS

We tested each browser on five fronts:

Features

Here we looked for features such as the functionality offered by the e-mail client bundled with the browser, facility for offline browsing, whether there is an Instant Messenger and how well integrated it is with the browser, whether it includes a bare bones, simple HTML editor, support for SSL (Secure Socket Layer) and 128-bit encryption, plugins, and any additional features that enhance the usability or functionality of the browser.

Size and usability

Here we checked for the amount of disk space a full install of a browser would take up, and the total memory utilised by a single instance of the browser (a single window and a single Web site open) while loading a standard HTML page. We also checked the load-up time (the time taken by the browser to launch after clicking on the icon).

Ease of use

We looked for features such as a shortcuts and the ability to complete a URL auto-

matically. We examined the look and feel—the aesthetics and accessibility of the browsers. We also examined the tools that make it easier to find and manage information and links on the Internet.

Performance

We ran the Caffeine Mark benchmark to check the browser's Java performance. Another test we ran was ZD's iBench, which is a measure of the Web page rendering speeds, cache retrieval speeds and refresh speeds of an Internet browser.

Compatibility

We checked for the browser's ability to display Cascading Style Sheets (CSS), nested tables, layers and other such HTML content.

The Weightages given to Different Parameters

■ Features (e-mail client, offline browsing, instant messenger, HTML editor, high encryption, plugin support, miscellaneous features) – 30 points

■ HTML Compatibility – 10 points

■ Ease of Use (shortcuts and auto-complete, look and feel, search and other tools) – 20 points

■ Performance (Caffeine bench, iBench) – 20 points

■ Size and usability (install size, memory usage, load-up time) – 20 points



Internet Explorer), browsers that use IE's engine to achieve HTML rendering etc, and offline browsers. Other browsers include those made to serve the needs of specific users (such as children or those who are visually impaired).

We tested the browsers that were meant to serve as a complete package in themselves, and those that serve a specific purpose. The complete ones were those that had their own rendering engine (Mozilla, Opera, and Internet Explorer). The other browsers were those that enhanced the browsing experience by offering either ease of use, multiple sites in one common window, a customisable interface or were exceptionally light browsers (K-Meleon, MSN Explorer, NetCaptor, NeoPlanet).

The Internet Communication Suites

These packages are more than just browsers—they include a host of other utilities such as an instant messenger, e-mail client, media player, download manager, etc. They are meant to serve a more holistic purpose of acting as a one-point

communications and Internet tool for you. Among the browsers tested in this category, IE 6 and NeoPlanet were based on the Internet Explorer engine, while Netscape 4.78, Netscape 6.1 and Mozilla 0.9.3 were based on the Netscape engine.

Speed and power

Faster, simpler and more powerful browsing—who wouldn't like the idea? Most browsers now have the auto complete feature, which makes for smart browsing. You just have to type in the name of the Web site and leave the rest to the browser.

Different browsers have different shortcuts. If you are an Internet Explorer user, all you have to do is to key in the Web site's URL, press

[Ctrl] and hit [Enter] (only if the Web site ends in .com). Similarly, if you are a Netscape or a Mozilla user, add the name followed by .com and hit Enter, and you reach your Web site. For NeoPlanet you can just type in the name and press Enter and it automatically takes you to the site.

Both versions of Netscape, Mozilla and NeoPlanet by default have a side tab bar, which



NeoPlanet 5.2 has a cool looking interface

Find it on
digit
interactive

More Info on
the test process and the
products tested, check out
Mindware

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